Interview playbook (Frameworks)

1. Spot the format from the first sentence

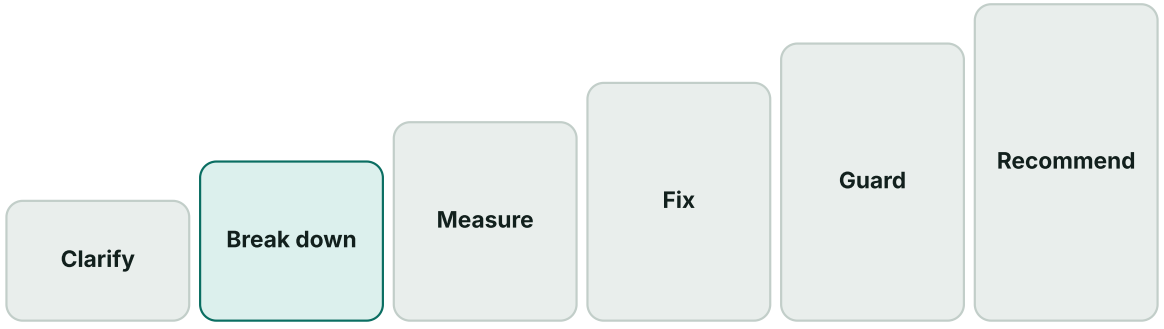
- 'It's broken / slow / expensive / unsafe' → **Fix it**
- 'Design / build / architect' → **Design it**
- 'Should we / what's your view' → **Business case**
- 'What is / compare' → **Explain it**
- 'How many / how much' → **Estimate**
- 'Tell me about a time' → **Behavioural**
- Data pack + deadline → **Written case** · recruiter call → **Screening**

> ⚠ Watch the ending: a number means estimate; 'should we' or 'what's your view' means business case; a symptom in an existing system means fix it.

2. Fix it: C · B · M · F · G · R

1. **Clarify**: restate, ask what's built, what's in place, what success means
2. **Break it down**: never skip. 'This is a cost problem, so I'll break it into...'
3. **Measure**: ask for data per piece, find the piece that moved ('the drop was sudden, so what changed?')
4. **Fix**: cheapest and safest first
5. **Guard**: every change passes the golden-set evals before shipping; monitor after
6. **Recommend**: answer first, reasons, next steps, risk

✎ DIAGRAM



Never say a fix before you've said the breakdown.

The fix-it script.

3. The breakdowns to memorise

✎ DIAGRAM

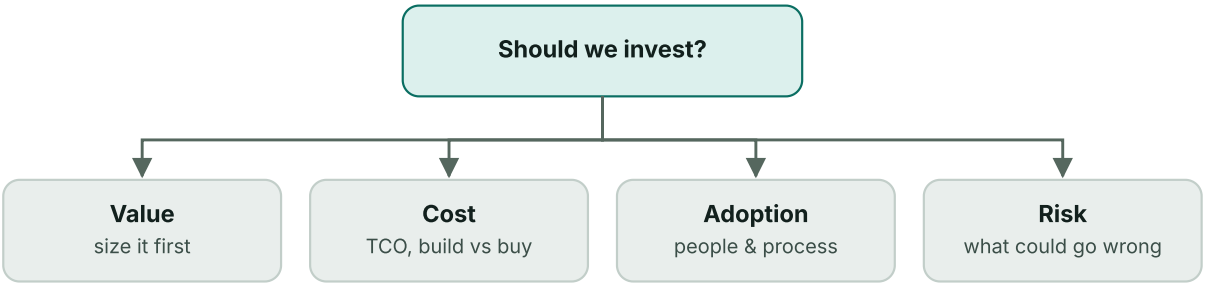
Problem	Break it into
Wrong answers	retrieval → generation
Too expensive	requests × tokens per request × price
Too slow	retrieval → reading → writing → streaming
Unsafe	inputs → tools → outputs
Is it good?	golden set → metrics → bar → CI → monitoring

Step 2 of the fix-it script for each kind of problem.

4. Business case

- Branches: **value** (first) → **cost** (build vs buy, full TCO) → **adoption** → **risk**
- Size value from the client's numbers; **challenge vendor claims** with reference customers
- Ask 'is that saving real?': time saved only becomes money if headcount changes or capacity is used (more patients, more leads)
- **Test the assumption**: 'what if it's 15% instead of 20%?'
- If it's marginal, **pilot where the value concentrates** (e.g. the 50 stores with 60% of the waste)
- Recommend: **answer + number + pilot + success bar + main risk**

✎ DIAGRAM



Start with value: if the prize is small, nothing else matters.

5. Tech maths

- **TCO** = buy/build + implement + train + run · **ROI** = (benefit − cost) ÷ cost · **Payback** = upfront ÷ annual savings
- Cost per message = monthly team cost ÷ messages (e.g. $75k ÷ 50k = $1.50)

6. Design it

- Clarify → requirements with numbers → **simplest working design** → where it breaks → evals and safety → trade-offs

7. Explain it (60 seconds)

- Define → mechanism → when (and when not) → trade-off → example
- Compare: shared goal → three differences → when each → your default

SAY IT

"Yes, but start with a pilot in X. It pays back in N months even at the low case. Success means Y; the main risk is Z, which we'd manage by W."